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Macro Perspectives on the Digital Economy

7AAVDE02

Module Handbook
2020/21

Module Team

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Seminar Leader	Dr Maha Shaikh maha.shaikh@kcl.ac.uk Dr Gregory Asmolov gregory.asmolov@kcl.ac.uk

Module Description

This module provides a systematic and critical reflection on the digital economy. With digital technologies becoming central to every aspect of the global economy, and with tech companies dominating the commanding heights of our economies, an understanding of our world today requires grappling with the changes that the digital economy is bringing about. This module will aim to give students the skills and knowledge necessary to carry out that task.

We will discuss current issues around the rise of tech companies, with a particular focus on their political economy. Should platforms like Facebook or Google be broken up? Why do companies like Uber and Airbnb tend towards a winner-takes-all model? What role does data play in the current economy and how do we value it? Why is addiction so prominent amongst social media apps? How is class changing within the digital economy? Why are Google and Amazon buying companies that have nothing to do with their core businesses? These types of questions will be examined and set in the context of larger political economy dynamics.

The political economy perspective will also allow us to highlight the role of power in the digital economy, and the ways in which new inequalities of power are emerging between the major platforms and everyone else. Students will be given the conceptual tools necessary for explaining these changes and for drawing out the systematic connections across the digital economy.

Assessment

1 x 4,000-word essay (100%). Choose one of the following questions and answer using the theories and ideas discussed in class:

1. To what extent is platform labour representative of the future of work?
2. Pick a core theory of the module (e.g. knowledge economy, cognitive capitalism, surveillance capitalism, platform capitalism, neo-feudalism, or 'something worse') and critically reflect on the strengths and weaknesses of its account of the current moment.
3. What is/are the most appropriate policy response(s) to the rise of platform monopolies?
4. Create your own question. You must focus on one of the weekly topics covered this semester, demonstrate a critical understanding of the topic, and get approval for your essay question from the module convenor.

Essays must be submitted electronically via the Turnitin section on the module's KEATS page.

Readings

As a Masters-level module, you are expected to read widely. Each week has required readings that will supplement the lectures. Please read these texts before each session and come prepared to discuss the readings. When reading papers, consider these four questions:

- 1) How would you summarise that paper, in a single sentence?
- 2) How does it differ from other perspectives on this topic?
- 3) What evidence is used to support the argument?
- 4) Do the data, methods, and argument justify the claims made? Why not?

Asking these questions (synthesising papers, questioning methods, practising 'active learning') will help you understand, remember, and critically engage with the readings.

Participation

Active student participation in this module is crucial. Students are expected to contribute to seminars, to develop and articulate their ideas, to pose critical questions and to define their position in relevant debates.

Students are expected to attend all lectures and seminars, and to show up on time. If you are unable to attend a session for any reason, please contact the convenor/tutor straight away.

Resources

These journals are all good places to start searching for research on any given topic:

- *AI & Society*
- *Big Data & Society*
- *Environment and Planning D: Society and Space*
- *Ephemera*
- *Feminist Media Studies*
- *Information, Communication & Society*
- *International Journal of Communication*
- *Journal of Information Technology*
- *Media, Culture & Society*
- *New Media & Society*
- *Surveillance & Society*
- *Technology and Culture*
- *tripleC: Communication, Capitalism & Critique*

Schedule

Part 1: Theories

Week 1	Introduction to Macro Perspectives
Week 2	The Knowledge Economy and Cognitive Capitalism

Part 2: Work and Class

Week 3	Digital Labour
Week 4	The Political Economy of Automation

Part 3: Critical Issues

Week 5	Platform Monopolies
Week 6	AI and the Economy
Week 7	Surveillance Capitalism
Week 8	Digital Colonialism

Part 4: Futures

Week 9	Capitalism or Something Worse?
Week 10	Alternative Futures

Week 1	Introduction to Macro Perspectives
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What does it mean to take a macro perspective on the digital economy? This week we will set out some of the foundational questions and the systemic theories that will guide the material in future weeks. In particular, we will look at what it means to live within a capitalist economy and how this structure shapes and incentivises the creation and use of new technologies.

Required Readings

- W. Brian Arthur, "The Second Economy," *McKinsey Quarterly*, 2011.

Further Resources

These are some core books on the topics of the module that you may want to read for your own enjoyment and to expand your knowledge of the field:

- Adam Arvidsson, *Changemakers: The Industrious Future of the Digital Economy* (Cambridge: Polity, 2019).
- Yochai Benkler, *The Wealth of Networks: How Social Production Transforms Markets and Freedom* (New Haven: Yale University Press, 2007).
- Yann Moulier Boutang, *Cognitive Capitalism* (Cambridge: Polity Press, 2012).
- Benjamin H. Bratton, *The Stack: On Software and Sovereignty* (Cambridge: The MIT Press, 2015).
- Harry Braverman, *Labor and Monopoly Capitalism: The Degradation of Work in the Twentieth Century*, 25th Anniversary Edition (New York: Monthly Review Press, 1999).
- Robert Brenner, "Property and Progress: Where Adam Smith Went Wrong," in *Marxist History-Writing for the Twenty-First Century*, ed. Chris Wickham (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2007), 49–111.
- Jessica Bruder, *Nomadland: Surviving America in the Twenty-First Century* (New York: W.W. Norton & Company, 2017).
- Callum Cant, *Riding for Deliveroo: Resistance in the New Economy* (Cambridge: Polity, 2020).
- Colin Crouch, *Will the Gig Economy Prevail?* (Cambridge: Polity, 2019).
- Michael A. Cusumano, Annabelle Gawer, and David B. Yoffie, *The Business of Platforms: Strategy in the Age of Digital Competition, Innovation, and Power* (New York: Harper Business, 2019).
- Brooke Erin Duffy, *(Not) Getting Paid to Do What You Love: Gender, Social Media, and Aspirational Work* (London: Yale University Press, 2017).

- Nick Dyer-Witheford, *Cyber-Proletariat: Global Labour in the Digital Vortex* (London: Pluto Press, 2015).
- Nick Dyer-Witheford, Atle Mikkola Kjosén, and James Steinhoff, *Inhuman Power: Artificial Intelligence and the Future of Capitalism* (Pluto Press, 2019).
- David S. Evans and Richard Schmalensee, *The Matchmakers: The New Economics of Multisided Platforms* (Boston: Harvard Business Review Press, 2016).
- André Gorz, *Paths to Paradise: On the Liberation from Work*, trans. Malcolm Imrie (Boston: South End Press, 1985).
- Mary L. Gray and Siddharth Suri, *Ghost Work: How to Stop Silicon Valley from Building a New Global Underclass* (Boston: Houghton Mifflin Harcourt USA, 2019).
- Jonathan Haskel and Stian Westlake, *Capitalism Without Capital: The Rise of the Intangible Economy* (Princeton: Princeton University Press, 2017).
- Ursula Huws, *Labor in the Global Digital Economy: The Cybertariat Comes of Age* (New York: Monthly Review Press, 2014).
- Tim Jordan, *The Digital Economy* (Cambridge: Polity, 2019).
- Kai-Fu Lee, *AI Superpowers: China, Silicon Valley, and the New World Order* (Boston: Houghton Mifflin Harcourt, 2018).
- Karl Marx, *Grundrisse: Introduction to the Critique of Political Economy*, trans. Martin Nicolaus (Middlesex: Penguin Books, 1973).
- David Noble, *Forces of Production: A Social History of Industrial Automation* (New York: Oxford University Press, 1986).
- Ramin Ramtin, *Capitalism and Automation: Revolution in Technology and Capitalist Breakdown* (London: Pluto Press, 1991).
- Sarah T. Roberts, *Behind the Screen: Content Moderation in the Shadows of Social Media* (New Haven: Yale University Press, 2019).
- Dan Schiller, *Digital Depression: Information Technology and Economic Crisis* (Chicago: University of Illinois Press, 2014).
- Trebor Scholz and Nathan Schneider, eds., *Ours to Hack and to Own: The Rise of Platform Cooperativism, a New Vision for the Future of Work and a Fairer Internet* (New York: OR Books, 2017).
- Juliet Schor, *After the Gig* (Oakland, California: California University Press, 2020).
- Nick Srnicek, *Platform Capitalism* (Cambridge: Polity Press, 2016).
- Bernard Stiegler, *The Age of Disruption: Technology and Madness in Computational Capitalism* (Cambridge: Polity, 2019).
- Maurice Stucke and Allen Grunes, *Big Data and Competition Policy* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2016).
- McKenzie Wark, *A Hacker Manifesto* (Cambridge: Harvard University Press, 2004).
- McKenzie Wark, *Capital Is Dead* (London: Verso, 2019).
- Tim Wu, *The Master Switch: The Rise and Fall of Information Empires* (London: Atlantic Books, 2012).
- Shoshana Zuboff, *The Age of Surveillance Capitalism: The Fight for a Human Future at the New Frontier of Power* (London: Profile Books, 2019).

Week 2	The Knowledge Economy and Cognitive Capitalism
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Theories of the digital economy have not sprung out of nowhere but have instead built upon earlier theories from the 1990s and 2000s about the rising importance of knowledge and other intangible goods. This week will examine these approaches, focusing on the mainstream image of the 'knowledge economy' as well as the more critical theory provided by 'cognitive capitalism'. The lecture will examine what makes this stage of capitalism distinct from earlier industrial periods and we will also consider the limits of these approaches – both in their own time and as the basis for a theory of the digital economy today.

Required Readings

- Yann Moulier Boutang, *Cognitive Capitalism* (Cambridge: Polity, 2012), chapter 3.
- George Caffentzis, "A Critique of 'Cognitive Capitalism,'" in *In Letters of Blood and Fire: Work, Machines, and the Crisis of Capitalism* (Oakland: PM Press, 2013), 95–123.

Further Resources

- James E. Bessen, "Accounting for Rising Corporate Profits: Intangibles or Regulatory Rents?," Boston Univ. School of Law, Law and Economics Research Paper No. 16-18 (Boston: Boston University School of Law, 2016).
- Armin Beverungen, Steffen Böhm, and Chris Land, "Free Labour, Social Media, Management: Challenging Marxist Organization Studies," *Organization Studies* 36, no. 4 (2015): 473–89.
- Claudio Celis Bueno, *The Attention Economy: Labour Time and Power in Cognitive Capitalism* (London: Rowman & Littlefield, 2016).
- Brett Caraway, "Crisis of Command: Theorizing Value in New Media," *Communication Theory* 26, no. 1 (2016): 64–81.
- Carol Corrado, Charles Hulten, and Daniel Sichel, "Intangible Capital and US Economic Growth," *Review of Income and Wealth* 55, no. 3 (2009): 661–85.
- Mark Coté and Jennifer Pybus, "Learning to Immaterial Labour 2.0," *Ephemera* 7, no. 1 (2007): 88–106.
- Christian Fuchs, *Digital Labour and Karl Marx* (New York: Routledge, 2014).
- Andrea Fumagalli and Stefano Lucarelli, "A Model of Cognitive Capitalism: A Preliminary Analysis," *European Journal of Economic and Social Systems* 20, no. 1 (2007): 117–33.
- Andrea Fumagalli, "Twenty Theses on Contemporary Capitalism (Cognitive Biocapitalism)," *Angelaki* 16, no. 3 (2011): 7–17.

- Andrea Fumagalli et al., *Cognitive Capitalism, Welfare and Labour: The Commonfare Hypothesis* (New York: Routledge, 2019).
- Jonathan Haskel and Stian Westlake, *Capitalism Without Capital: The Rise of the Intangible Economy* (Princeton: Princeton University Press, 2017).
- David Hesmondhalgh, "User-Generated Content, Free Labour and the Cultural Industries," *Ephemera* 10, no. 3/4 (2010): 267–84.
- Kylie Jarrett, "The Relevance of 'Women's Work': Social Reproduction and Immaterial Labor in Digital Media," *Television & New Media* 15, no. 1 (2014): 14–29.
- Kylie Jarrett, "Devaluing Binaries: Marxist Feminism and the Value of Consumer Labour," in *Reconsidering Value and Labour in the Digital Age*, ed. Eran Fisher and Christian Fuchs (Houndmills: Palgrave Macmillan, 2015), 207–23.
- Michael A. Lebowitz, "Too Many Blindspots on the Media," *Studies in Political Economy* 21, no. 1 (1986): 165–73.
- Nick O'Donovan, "From Knowledge Economy to Automation Anxiety: A Growth Regime in Crisis?," *New Political Economy* 25, no. 2 (2020): 248–66.
- OECD, "The Knowledge-Based Economy" (Paris: Organisation for Economic Co-operation and Development, 1996).
- Sanna Ojanperä, Mark Graham, and Matthew Zook, "The Digital Knowledge Economy Index: Mapping Content Production," *The Journal of Development Studies* 55, no. 12 (December 2, 2019): 2626–43.
- Matteo Pasquinelli, "Google's PageRank Algorithm: A Diagram of Cognitive Capitalism and the Rentier of the Common Intellect," in *Deep Search*, eds. Konrad Becker and Felix Stalder (London: Transaction Publishers, 2009).
- Walter Powell and Kaisa Snellman, "The Knowledge Economy," *Annual Review of Sociology* 30, no. 1 (2004): 199–220.
- Bruce Robinson, "With a Different Marx: Value and the Contradictions of Web 2.0 Capitalism," *The Information Society* 31, no. 1 (2015): 44–51.
- Dallas Smythe, "Communications: Blindspot of Western Marxism," *Canadian Journal of Political and Social Theory* 1, no. 3 (1977): 1–27.
- Prasanna Tambe et al., "IT, AI and the Growth of Intangible Capital," SSRN Scholarly Paper (Rochester: Social Science Research Network, 2019).
- Tiziana Terranova, "Free Labor: Producing Culture for the Digital Economy," *Social Text* 18, no. 2 (2000): 33–58.
- Carlo Vercellone, "From Formal Subsumption to General Intellect: Elements for a Marxist Reading of the Thesis of Cognitive Capitalism," *Historical Materialism* 15, no. 1 (2007): 13–36.
- Carlo Vercellone, "The Becoming Rent of Profit? The New Articulation of Wage, Rent and Profit," *Knowledge Cultures* 1, no. 2 (2013): 264–77.
- McKenzie Wark, *A Hacker Manifesto* (Cambridge: Harvard University Press, 2004).
- McKenzie Wark, *Capital Is Dead* (London: Verso, 2019).

Week 3	Digital Labour
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The emerging digital economy has given rise to a wide new array of jobs. This week will examine how work and workplaces are being reorganised thanks to digital technology, including crowdsourced labour, the emerging gig economy, creative workers, and micro-celebrities. We will also look at how digital platforms are enabling new forms of exploitation and new modes of algorithmic management.

Required Readings

- Katherine C. Kellogg, Melissa A. Valentine, and Angèle Christin, "Algorithms at Work: The New Contested Terrain of Control," *Academy of Management Annals* 14, no. 1 (2020): 366–410.
- Steven Vallas and Juliet B. Schor, "What Do Platforms Do? Understanding the Gig Economy," *Annual Review of Sociology* 46, no. 1 (2020).

Further Resources

- Ifeoma Ajunwa, Kate Crawford, and Jason Schultz, "Limitless Worker Surveillance," *California Law Review* 105, no. 3 (2017): 735–76.
- Mohammad Amir Anwar and Mark Graham, "Digital Labour at Economic Margins: African Workers and the Global Information Economy," *Review of African Political Economy* 47, no. 163 (2020): 95–105.
- Janine Berg, "Income Security in the On-Demand Economy: Findings and Policy Lessons from a Survey of Crowdworkers," ILO Working Paper (Geneva: International Labour Organization, 2016).
- Harry Braverman, *Labor and Monopoly Capitalism: The Degradation of Work in the Twentieth Century*, 25th Anniversary Edition (New York: Monthly Review Press, 1999).
- Jessica Bruder, *Nomadland: Surviving America in the Twenty-First Century* (New York: W.W. Norton & Company, 2017).
- Ryan Calo and Alex Rosenblat, "The Taking Economy: Uber, Information, and Power," *Columbia Law Review* 117, no. 6 (2017): 1623–90.
- Callum Cant, *Riding for Deliveroo: Resistance in the New Economy* (Cambridge: Polity, 2020).
- Antonio Casilli, "Digital Labor Studies Go Global: Toward a Digital Decolonial Turn," *International Journal of Communication* 11 (2017): 3934–54.
- Jenny Chan, Mark Selden, and Pun Ngai, *Dying for an iPhone: Apple, Foxconn and the Lives of China's Workers* (London: Pluto Press, 2020).
- Cristiano Codagnone, Fabienne Abadie, and Federico Biagi, "The Future of Work in the 'Sharing Economy': Market Efficiency and Equitable Opportunities or Unfair

Precarisation?," JRC Science for Policy Report EUR 27913 (Institute for Prospective Technological Studies, 2016).

- Colin Crouch, *Will the Gig Economy Prevail?* (Cambridge: Polity, 2019).
- Valerio De Stefano, "The Rise of the 'Just-in-Time Workforce': On-Demand Work, Crowdwork and Labour Protection in the 'Gig-Economy,'" *Conditions of Work and Employment Series*, No. 71 (Geneva: International Labour Organization, 2016).
- Valerio De Stefano and Antonio Aloisi, "European Legal Framework for 'Digital Labour Platforms'" (Luxembourg: European Commission, 2018).
- Niels van Doorn, Eva Mos, and Jelke Bosma, "Disrupting 'Business as Usual': How Covid-19 Is Impacting Platform-Mediated Labor and Social Reproduction," *Platform Labor*, March 27, 2020.
- Brooke Erin Duffy, *(Not) Getting Paid to Do What You Love: Gender, Social Media, and Aspirational Work* (London: Yale University Press, 2017).
- Nick Dyer-Witheford, *Cyber-Proletariat: Global Labour in the Digital Vortex* (London: Pluto Press, 2015).
- Sai Englert, Jamie Woodcock, and Callum Cant, "Digital Workerism: Technology, Platforms, and the Circulation of Workers' Struggles," *TripleC: Communication, Capitalism & Critique* 18, no. 1 (2020): 132–45.
- Chris Forde et al., "The Social Protection of Workers in the Platform Economy" (Brussels: European Parliament Policy Department A: Economic and Scientific Policy, 2017).
- Mary L. Gray and Siddharth Suri, *Ghost Work: How to Stop Silicon Valley from Building a New Global Underclass* (Boston: Houghton Mifflin Harcourt USA, 2019).
- Melissa Gregg, "The Normalisation of Flexible Female Labour in the Information Economy," *Feminist Media Studies* 8, no. 3 (2008): 285–99.
- Seth Harris and Alan Krueger, "A Proposal for Modernizing Labor Laws for Twenty-First Century Work: The 'Independent Worker'" (Washington, D.C.: The Hamilton Project, 2015).
- Lyn Hoang, Grant Blank, and Anabel Quan-Haase, "The Winners and the Losers of the Platform Economy: Who Participates?," *Information, Communication & Society*, 2020, 1–20.
- Ursula Huws, "Logged Labour: A New Paradigm of Work Organisation?," *Work Organisation, Labour & Globalisation* 10, no. 1 (2016): 7–26.
- Ursula Huws, *Labor in the Global Digital Economy: The Cybertariat Comes of Age* (New York: Monthly Review Press, 2014).
- Ursula Huws et al., "The Platformisation of Work in Europe: Results from Research in 13 European Countries" (Brussels: Foundation for European Progressive Studies, UNI Europa, and University of Hertfordshire, 2019).
- IG Metall, "Frankfurt Paper on Platform-Based Work" (Frankfurt, 2016).
- Lilly C. Irani and Michael "Six" Silberman, "Turkopticon: Interrupting Worker Invisibility in Amazon Mechanical Turk," in *Proceedings of the SIGCHI Conference*

on Human Factors in Computing Systems, CHI '13 (Paris: Association for Computing Machinery, 2013), 611–620.

- Stephen Marglin, “What Do Bosses Do? The Origins and Functions of Hierarchy in Capitalist Production,” *Review of Radical Political Economics* 6, no. 2 (1974): 60–112.
- Gina Neff, *Venture Labour: Work and the Burden of Risk in Innovative Industries* (Cambridge: MIT Press, 2015).
- OECD, “Policy Responses to New Forms of Work” (Paris: Organisation for Economic Co-operation and Development, 2019).
- Kapila Perera, Jacob Ohrvik-Stott, and Catherine Miller, “Better Work in the Gig Economy” (London: doteveryone, 2020).
- Annarosa Pesole et al., “Platform Workers in Europe: Evidence from the COLLEEM Survey,” EUR - Scientific and Technical Research Reports (Publications Office of the European Union, 2018), JRC112157.
- Jeremias Prassl, *Humans as a Service: The Promise and Perils of Work in the Gig Economy* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2019).
- Sarah T. Roberts, *Behind the Screen: Content Moderation in the Shadows of Social Media* (New Haven: Yale University Press, 2019).
- Alex Rosenblat et al., “Discriminating Tastes: Uber’s Customer Ratings as Vehicles for Workplace Discrimination,” *Policy & Internet* 9, no. 3 (2017): 256–79.
- Alex Rosenblat and Luke Stark, “Algorithmic Labor and Information Asymmetries: A Case Study of Uber’s Drivers,” *International Journal of Communication* 10 (2016): 3758–84.
- Marion Schmid-Drüner, “The Situation of Workers in the Collaborative Economy” (Brussels: European Parliament, 2016).
- Juliet Schor, *After the Gig* (Oakland, California: California University Press, 2020).
- Saori Shibata, “Gig Work and the Discourse of Autonomy: Fictitious Freedom in Japan’s Digital Economy,” *New Political Economy* 25, no. 4 (2020): 535–51.
- Michael “Six” Silberman, “Fifteen Criteria for a Fairer Gig Economy,” in *Towards a Fairer Gig Economy*, ed. Mark Graham and Joe Shaw (London: Meatspace Press, 2017), 16–19.
- Jim Stanford, “The Resurgence of Gig Work: Historical and Theoretical Perspectives,” *The Economic and Labour Relations Review* 28, no. 3 (2017): 382–401.
- Kathleen Thelen, “Regulating Uber: The Politics of the Platform Economy in Europe and the United States,” *Perspectives on Politics* 16, no. 4 (2018): 938–53.
- Alex Wood, *Despotism on Demand: How Power Operates in the Flexible Workplace* (Ithaca: Cornell University Press, 2020).
- Jamie Woodcock and Mark Graham, *The Gig Economy: A Critical Introduction* (Cambridge: Polity, 2019).

Week 4	The Political Economy of Automation
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The media is awash with worries about robots taking jobs. A whole new series of technologies appears on the verge of eliminating a vast swath of existing work. This week will examine the debates surrounding automation and work. What role does automation play under capitalism? How does the current anxiety about automation differ – if at all – from previous periods of concern? And to what extent do these technological shifts exacerbate ongoing labour market trends towards precarity, flexibilization, stagnating wages, and job polarisation?

Required Readings

- Aaron Benanav, “Automation and the Future of Work—1,” *New Left Review* 119 (2019): 5–38.
- David Noble, *Forces of Production: A Social History of Industrial Automation* (New York: Oxford University Press, 1986), chapter 7.

Further Resources

- Stephanie Aaronson et al., “Labor Force Participation: Recent Developments and Future Prospects” (Brookings Institution, 2014).
- Daron Acemoglu, “Technical Change, Inequality, and the Labor Market,” *Journal of Economic Literature* 40, no. 1 (2002): 7–72.
- Daron Acemoglu and Pascual Restrepo, “Automation and New Tasks: How Technology Displaces and Reinstates Labor,” *Journal of Economic Perspectives* 33, no. 2 (2019): 3–30.
- Stanley Aronowitz et al., “The Post-Work Manifesto,” in *Post-Work: The Wages of Cybernation*, ed. Stanley Aronowitz and Jonathan Cutler (New York: Routledge, 1998), 31–80.
- David Autor and David Dorn, “The Growth of Low-Skill Service Jobs and the Polarization of the US Labor Market,” *American Economic Review* 103, no. 5 (2013): 1553–97.
- David Autor, “Polanyi’s Paradox and the Shape of Employment Growth,” Working Paper (National Bureau of Economic Research, September 2014).
- David Autor, “Why Are There Still So Many Jobs? The History and Future of Workplace Automation,” *Journal of Economic Perspectives* 29, no. 3 (2015): 3–30.
- David Autor, Frank Levy, and Richard Murnane, “The Skill Content of Recent Technological Change: An Empirical Exploration,” *The Quarterly Journal of Economics* 118, no. 4 (2003): 1279–1333.
- Aaron Benanav and Endnotes, “Misery and Debt,” in *Endnotes 2: Misery and the Value Form* (London: Endnotes, 2010), 20–66.

- Aaron Benanav, *Automation and the Future of Work* (London: Verso, 2020).
- James Boggs, *American Revolution: Pages from a Negro Worker's Notebook* (New York: Monthly Review Press, 2009).
- Erik Brynjolfsson and Andrew McAfee, *The Second Machine Age: Work, Progress, and Prosperity in a Time of Brilliant Technologies* (New York: W. W. Norton & Company, 2014).
- Ruth Schwartz Cowan, *More Work for Mother: The Ironies of Household Technology from the Open Hearth to the Microwave* (London: Free Association Books, 1989).
- Guido Matias Cortes, Nir Jaimovich, and Henry Siu, "Disappearing Routine Jobs: Who, How, and Why?," *Journal of Monetary Economics* 91 (2017): 69–87.
- Nancy Folbre, "Nursebots to the Rescue? Immigration, Automation, and Care," *Globalizations* 3, no. 3 (2006): 349–60.
- Leopoldina Fortunati, "Robotization and the Domestic Sphere," *New Media & Society*, 2018.
- Carl Benedikt Frey and Michael Osborne, "The Future of Employment: How Susceptible Are Jobs to Computerisation?," 2013.
- Martin Ford. *The Rise of the Robots: Technology and the Threat of a Jobless Future* (Basic Books, 2016).
- Maarten Goos and Alan Manning, "Lousy and Lovely Jobs: The Rising Polarisation of Work in Britain," *Review of Economics and Statistics* 89, no. 1 (2007): 118–133.
- Maarten Goos, et al. "Job Polarization in Europe," *American Economic Review* 99 no. 2 (2009): 58–63.
- André Gorz, *Paths to Paradise: On the Liberation from Work*, trans. Malcolm Imrie (Boston: South End Press, 1985).
- André Gorz, *Farewell to the Working Class: An Essay on Post-Industrial Socialism*, trans. Michael Sonenscher (London: Pluto Press, 1997).
- Cedric Johnson, "James Boggs, the 'Outsiders,' and the Challenge of Postindustrial Society," *Souls* 13, no. 3 (2011): 303–26.
- John Maynard Keynes, "Economic Possibilities for Our Grandchildren," in *Essays in Persuasion* (New York: W.W. Norton & Company, 1963), 358–73.
- Peter Linebaugh, *Ned Ludd & Queen Mab: Machine Breaking, Romanticism, and the Several Commons of 1811–12* (Oakland: PM Press, 2012).
- Karl Marx, *Capital: A Critique of Political Economy, Volume I*, trans. Ben Fowkes (London: Penguin Classics, 1990).
- Karl Marx, *Grundrisse: Introduction to the Critique of Political Economy*, trans. Martin Nicolaus (Middlesex: Penguin Books, 1973).
- Paul Mason, *Postcapitalism: A Guide to Our Future* (London: Allen Lane, 2015).
- Paul Mattick, "The Economics of Cybernation," *New Politics* 1, no. 4 (1962): 18–33.
- Joel Mokyr, et al., "The History of Technological Anxiety and the Future of Economic Growth: Is This Time Different?" *Journal of Economic Perspectives* 29, no. 3 (2015): 31–50.

- Jamie Morgan, "Will We Work in Twenty-First Century Capitalism? A Critique of the Fourth Industrial Revolution Literature," *Economy and Society* 48, no. 3 (2019): 371–98.
- Tessa Morris-Suzuki, "Robots and Capitalism," in *Cutting Edge: Technology, Information, Capitalism and Social Revolution*, ed. Jim Davis, Thomas Hirschl, and Michael Stack (London: Verso, 1997), 13–27.
- Nick O'Donovan, "From Knowledge Economy to Automation Anxiety: A Growth Regime in Crisis?," *New Political Economy* 25, no. 2 (2020): 248–66.
- Erwin Prassler et al., "A Short History of Cleaning Robots," *Autonomous Robots* 9, no. 3 (2000): 211–26.
- Gill Pratt, "Is a Cambrian Explosion Coming for Robotics?" *Journal of Economic Perspectives* 29, no. 3 (2015): 51–60.
- J. Jesse Ramírez, "Marcuse Among the Technocrats: America, Automation, and Postcapitalist Utopias, 1900–1941," *American Studies* 57, no. 1 (2012): 31–50.
- Ramin Ramtin, *Capitalism and Automation: Revolution in Technology and Capitalist Breakdown* (London: Pluto Press, 1991).
- Ramin Ramtin, "A Note on Automation and Alienation," in *Cutting Edge: Technology, Information, Capitalism and Social Revolution*, ed. Jim Davis, Thomas Hirschl, and Michael Stack (London: Verso, 1997), 243–52.
- Carys Roberts, Mathew Lawrence, and Loren King, "Managing Automation: Employment, Inequality and Ethics in the Digital Age" (London: Institute for Public Policy Research, 2017).
- Lukas Schlogl and Andy Sumner, "The Rise of the Robot Reserve Army: Automation and the Future of Economic Development, Work, and Wages in Developing Countries" (London: Center for Global Development, 2018).
- Jason Smith, *Smart Machines and Service Work: Automation in an Age of Stagnation* (London: Reaktion Books, 2020).
- David Spencer, "Work in and Beyond the Second Machine Age: The Politics of Production and Digital Technologies," *Work, Employment and Society* 31, no. 1 (2017): 142–52.
- David Spencer, "Fear and Hope in an Age of Mass Automation: Debating the Future of Work," *New Technology, Work and Employment* 33, no. 1 (2018): 1–12.
- Nick Srnicek and Alex Williams, *Inventing the Future: Postcapitalism and a World Without Work* (London: Verso, 2015).
- Ian Steedman, "Robots and Capitalism: A Clarification," *New Left Review*, no. 151 (1985): 125–28.
- UNCTAD, "Robots and Industrialization in Developing Countries" (Geneva, 2016).
- Stan Weir, *Singlejack Solidarity* (Minneapolis: University of Minnesota Press, 2004).
- Björn Westergård, "Do Computers Follow Rules Once Followed by Workers?," *IEEE Annals of the History of Computing* 39 (2017): 5–8.

Week 5	Platform Monopolies
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Common to many of the most profitable and powerful tech companies today is a new type of business model: the digital platform. Rather than producing goods and selling them to consumers, the platform aims to provide an infrastructure for different groups to come together. This week will examine this new business model, looking at what makes it different, what dynamics it produces, and why it is generating the largest companies the world has ever seen. We will also briefly look at antitrust responses and why regulators struggle to gain any control over these companies.

Required Readings

- Diane Coyle, "Practical Competition Policy Implications of Digital Platforms," Working Paper (Cambridge: Bennett Institute for Public Policy, 2018).
- Lina Khan, "Amazon's Antitrust Paradox," *Yale Law Journal* 126, no. 3 (2017): 710–805.

Further Resources

- Autorité de la Concurrence and Bundeskartellamt, "Algorithms and Competition" (Berlin, 2019).
- James Bessen, "Information Technology and Industry Concentration," Law & Economics Paper No. 17-41 (Boston: Boston University School of Law, 2017).
- Bruce A. Blonigen and Justin R. Pierce, "Evidence for the Effects of Mergers on Market Power and Efficiency," Working Paper (National Bureau of Economic Research, 2016).
- Carliss Baldwin and C. Jason Woodard, "The Architecture of Platforms: A Unified View," in *Platforms, Markets and Innovation*, ed. Annabelle Gawer (Cheltenham: Edward Elgar Publishing Limited, 2009), 19–44.
- Paul Baran and Paul Sweezy, *Monopoly Capital: An Essay on the American Economic and Social Order* (Middlesex: Penguin Books, 1966).
- Robert H. Bork and J. Gregory Sidak, "What Does the Chicago School Teach About Internet Search and the Antitrust Treatment of Google?," *Journal of Competition Law & Economics* 8, no. 4 (2012): 663–700.
- Susan Crawford, *Captive Audience: The Telecom Industry and Monopoly Power in the New Gilded Age* (New Haven: Yale University Press, 2014).
- Michael A. Cusumano, Annabelle Gawer, and David B. Yoffie, *The Business of Platforms: Strategy in the Age of Digital Competition, Innovation, and Power* (New York: Harper Business, 2019).
- William Davies, "Economics and the 'Nonsense' of Law: The Case of the Chicago Antitrust Revolution," *Economy and Society* 39, no. 1 (2010): 64–83.

- Jan De Loecker and Jan Eeckhout, "The Rise of Market Power and the Macroeconomic Implications," Working Paper (National Bureau of Economic Research, 2017).
- David Evans and Richard Schmalensee, "The Antitrust Analysis of Multi-Sided Platform Businesses," Working Paper No. 623 (Coase-Sandor Institute for Law & Economics, 2012).
- David S. Evans and Richard Schmalensee, *The Matchmakers: The New Economics of Multisided Platforms* (Boston: Harvard Business Review Press, 2016).
- Ariel Ezrachi and Maurice E. Stucke, *Virtual Competition: The Promise and Perils of the Algorithm-Driven Economy* (Cambridge: Harvard University Press, 2016).
- Ariel Ezrachi and Maurice E. Stucke, "Artificial Intelligence & Collusion: When Computers Inhibit Competition," SSRN Scholarly Paper (Rochester, NY: Social Science Research Network, 2015).
- Maryam Farboodi et al., "Big Data and Firm Dynamics," *AEA Papers and Proceedings* 109 (2019): 38–42.
- Annabelle Gawer (ed.) *Platforms, Markets and Innovation* (Cheltenham: Edward Elgar Publishing Limited, 2009).
- Annabelle Gawer, "Bridging Differing Perspectives on Technological Platforms: Toward an Integrative Framework," *Research Policy* 43, no. 7 (2014): 1239–49.
- Peter Evans and Annabelle Gawer, "The Rise of the Platform Enterprise: A Global Survey" (New York: The Center for Global Enterprise, 2016).
- Inge Graef, "Market Definition and Market Power in Data: The Case of Online Platforms," *World Competition: Law and Economics Review* 38, no. 4 (2015): 473–506.
- Inge Graef, "When Data Evolves into Market Power - Data Concentration and Data Abuse under Competition Law," in *Digital Dominance: The Power of Google, Amazon, Facebook, and Apple*, ed. Martin Moore and Damian Tambini (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2018), 71–97.
- Pamela Jones Harbour and Tara Isa Koslov, "Section 2 in a Web 2.0 World: An Expanded Vision of Relevant Product Markets," *Antitrust Law Journal* 76, no. 3 (2010): 769–97.
- Gary Clyde Hufbauer and Jisun Kim, "International Competition Policy and the WTO" (One Year Later: The Antitrust Modernization Commission's Report and the Challenges that Await Antitrust, New York University, April 11, 2008).
- Lina Khan, "Amazon - An Infrastructure Service and Its Challenge to Current Antitrust Law," in *Digital Dominance: The Power of Google, Amazon, Facebook, and Apple*, ed. Martin Moore and Damian Tambini (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2018), 98–129.
- Barry Lynn, *Cornered: The New Monopoly Capitalism and the Economics of Destruction* (Hoboken: John Wiley & Sons, Inc., 2010).
- Orla Lynskey, "Regulating 'Platform Power'" (London: London School of Economics and Political Science, 2017).

- Michelle Meagher, *Competition Is Killing Us: How Big Business Is Harming Our Society and Planet - And What To Do About It* (London: Penguin Business, 2020).
- Nathan Newman, "Search, Antitrust, and the Economics of the Control of User Data," *Yale Journal on Regulation* 31, no. 2 (2014).
- Geoffrey Parker and Marshall van Alstyne, "Two-Sided Network Effects: A Theory of Information Product Design," *Management Science* 51, no. 10 (2005): 1494–1504.
- Geoffrey G. Parker, Marshall W. Van Alstyne, and Sangeet Paul Choudary, *Platform Revolution: How Networked Markets Are Transforming the Economy and How to Make Them Work for You* (London: W. W. Norton & Company, 2017).
- Mark Patterson, *Antitrust Law in the New Economy: Google, Yelp, LIBOR, and the Control of Information* (Cambridge: Harvard University Press, 2017).
- Andrea Prat and Tommaso M. Valletti, "Attention Oligopoly," SSRN Scholarly Paper (Rochester: Social Science Research Network, 2019).
- K. Sabeel Rahman, "Regulating Informational Infrastructure: Internet Platforms as the New Public Utilities," *Georgetown Law Technology Review* 2, no. 2 (2018).
- K. Sabeel Rahman, "The New Utilities: Private Power, Social Infrastructure, and the Revival of the Public Utility Concept," *Cardozo Law Review* 39, no. 5 (2018): 1621–89.
- Jean-Charles Rochet and Jean Tirole, "Platform Competition in Two-Sided Markets," *Journal of the European Economic Association* 1, no. 4 (2003): 990–1029.
- Jean-Charles Rochet and Jean Tirole, "Two-Sided Markets: A Progress Report," *The RAND Journal of Economics* 37, no. 3 (2006): 645–67.
- Marshall Soules, "Harold Adams Innis: The Bias of Communication and Monopolies of Power," *MediaStudies* (2007).
- Nick Srnicek, *Platform Capitalism* (Cambridge: Polity Press, 2016).
- Nick Srnicek, "Platform Monopolies and the Political Economy of AI," in *Economics for the Many*, ed. John McDonnell (London: Verso, 2018), 152–63.
- Maurice Stucke and Allen Grunes, *Big Data and Competition Policy* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2016).
- Jonathan Taplin, *Move Fast and Break Things: How Facebook, Google, and Amazon Have Cornered Culture and What It Means For All Of Us* (London: Macmillan, 2017).
- Marshall W. Van Alstyne, Geoffrey G. Parker, and Sangeet Paul Choudary, "Pipelines, Platforms, and the New Rules of Strategy," *Harvard Business Review*, 2016.
- Tim Wu, *The Master Switch: The Rise and Fall of Information Empires* (London: Atlantic Books, 2012).
- Tim Wu, *The Curse of Bigness: Antitrust in the New Gilded Age* (New York: Columbia Global Reports, 2018).

Week 6	AI and the Economy
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With the rise of deep learning over the past decade, artificial intelligence has begun to transform numerous aspects of our economies. This week will look at what these impacts have been and what they might be in the future. Do historical patterns of hype and bust look set to prevail again? How is AI featuring in the strategies of the largest platforms? And to what extent is artificial intelligence simply a form of ‘artificial artificial intelligence’, dependent on human workers behind the scenes?

Required Readings

- Kate Crawford and Vladan Joler, “Anatomy of an AI System,” *Anatomy of an AI System*, 2018.
- Nick Dyer-Witheford, Atle Mikkola Kjosen, and James Steinhoff, *Inhuman Power: Artificial Intelligence and the Future of Capitalism* (Pluto Press, 2019), chapter 1.

Further Resources

- Daron Acemoglu and Pascual Restrepo, “The Wrong Kind of AI? Artificial Intelligence and the Future of Labour Demand,” *Cambridge Journal of Regions, Economy and Society*, 2020.
- Ajay Agrawal, Joshua Gans, and Avi Goldfarb, “Economic Policy for Artificial Intelligence,” Working Paper (National Bureau of Economic Research, 2018).
- Ajay Agrawal, Joshua Gans, and Avi Goldfarb, *Prediction Machines: The Simple Economics of Artificial Intelligence* (Boston: Harvard Business Review Press, 2018), chapters 7-11.
- Dario Amodei and Danny Hernandez, “AI and Compute,” OpenAI, May 16, 2018.
- Timothy F. Bresnahan and M. Trajtenberg, “General Purpose Technologies: ‘Engines of Growth’?,” *Journal of Econometrics* 65, no. 1 (1995): 83–108.
- Martin Casado and Peter Lauten, “The Empty Promise of Data Moats,” *Andreessen Horowitz* (blog), May 9, 2019.
- Martin Casado and Matt Bornstein, “The New Business of AI (and How It’s Different from Traditional Software),” *Andreessen Horowitz* (blog), February 16, 2020.
- European Commission, “A European Strategy for Data” (Brussels, 2020).
- Benedict Evans, “Does AI Make Strong Tech Companies Stronger?,” *Benedict Evans* (blog), December 20, 2018.
- Benedict Evans, “Machine Learning Deployment,” *Benedict Evans* (blog), October 4, 2019.
- Ariel Ezrachi and Maurice E. Stucke, “Artificial Intelligence & Collusion: When Computers Inhibit Competition,” SSRN Scholarly Paper (Rochester, NY: Social Science Research Network, 2015).

- Ariel Ezrachi and Maurice E. Stucke, "Is Your Digital Assistant Devious?," SSRN Scholarly Paper (Rochester, NY: Social Science Research Network, 2016).
- Morgan R. Frank et al., "Toward Understanding the Impact of Artificial Intelligence on Labor," *Proceedings of the National Academy of Sciences* 116, no. 14 (2019): 6531–39.
- Jason Furman and Robert Seamans, "AI and the Economy," Working Paper (National Bureau of Economic Research, 2018).
- Mary L. Gray and Siddharth Suri, *Ghost Work: How to Stop Silicon Valley from Building a New Global Underclass* (Boston: Houghton Mifflin Harcourt USA, 2019), chapter 1.
- Tim Hwang, "Computational Power and the Social Impact of Artificial Intelligence," SSRN Scholarly Paper (Rochester: Social Science Research Network, 2018).
- Martin Kenney and John Zysman, "The Platform Economy: Restructuring the Space of Capitalist Accumulation," *Cambridge Journal of Regions, Economy and Society* 13, no. 1 (2020): 55–76.
- Kai-Fu Lee, *AI Superpowers: China, Silicon Valley, and the New World Order* (Boston: Houghton Mifflin Harcourt, 2018).
- Vikram Mahidhar and Thomas H. Davenport, "Why Companies That Wait to Adopt AI May Never Catch Up," *Harvard Business Review*, December 6, 2018.
- Vidushi Marda, "Artificial Intelligence Policy in India: A Framework for Engaging the Limits of Data-Driven Decision-Making," *Philosophical Transactions of the Royal Society A* 376, no. 2133 (2018).
- Shakir Mohamed, Marie-Therese Png, and William Isaac, "Decolonial AI: Decolonial Theory as Sociotechnical Foresight in Artificial Intelligence," *Philosophy & Technology*, 2020.
- Tomasz Mucha and Timo Seppala, "Artificial Intelligence Platforms: A New Research Agenda for Digital Platform Economy," ETLA Working Paper (Helsinki: Elinkeinoelämän Tutkimuslaitos, 2020).
- Royal Society and British Academy, "The Impact of Artificial Intelligence on Work" (London, 2018).
- Nick Srnicek, "Platform Monopolies and the Political Economy of AI," in *Economics for the Many*, ed. John McDonnell (London: Verso, 2018), 152–63.
- Chen Sun et al., "Revisiting Unreasonable Effectiveness of Data in Deep Learning Era," *ArXiv*, 2017.
- Manuel Trajtenberg, "AI as the next GPT: A Political-Economy Perspective," Working Paper (National Bureau of Economic Research, 2018).
- Hal Varian, "Artificial Intelligence, Economics, and Industrial Organization," Working Paper (National Bureau of Economic Research, 2018).
- Amy Webb, *The Big Nine: How the Tech Titans & Their Thinking Machines Could Warp Humanity* (New York: PublicAffairs, 2019).
- Shivon Zilis, et al. "The Competitive Landscape for Machine Intelligence," *Harvard Business Review* (2016).

Week 7	Surveillance Capitalism
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With the vast amounts of data being created today, it was inevitable that a massive industry would rise up to manage and monetise these flows of data. This week looks at the theory of surveillance capitalism as a way to understand these changes. We will look at the shadowy world of data brokers and the increasingly sophisticated tools being used to monitor our behaviours online and offline. We will also interrogate the potential limits of the theory of surveillance capitalism and ask whether or not it misses more fundamental problems with the digital economy.

Required Readings

- Evgeny Morozov, "Capitalism's New Clothes," *The Baffler*, February 4, 2019.
- Shoshana Zuboff, *The Age of Surveillance Capitalism: The Fight for a Human Future at the New Frontier of Power* (London: Profile Books, 2019), chapter 5.

Further Resources

- Ifeoma Ajunwa, Kate Crawford, and Jason Schultz, "Limitless Worker Surveillance," *California Law Review* 105, no. 3 (2017): 735–76.
- Mark Andrejevic, "Surveillance in the Big Data Era," in *Emerging Pervasive Information and Communication Technologies (PICT)*, ed. Kenneth D. Pimble, Law, Governance and Technology Series 11 (Springer Netherlands, 2014), 55–69.
- Payal Arora, "Decolonizing Privacy Studies," *Television & New Media* 20, no. 4 (2019): 366–78.
- Claudio Celis Bueno, *The Attention Economy: Labour Time and Power in Cognitive Capitalism* (London: Rowman & Littlefield, 2016).
- Wolfie Christl and Sarah Spiekermann, *Networks of Control: A Report on Corporate Surveillance, Digital Tracking, Big Data & Privacy* (Vienna: Facultas Verlags, 2016).
- Yves Citton, *The Ecology of Attention* (Cambridge: Polity, 2017).
- Julie Cohen, "The Surveillance-Innovation Complex: The Irony of the Participatory Turn," in *The Participatory Condition in the Digital Age*, ed. Darin Barney et al. (Minneapolis: University of Minnesota Press, 2016), 207–26.
- Nicole Cohen, "The Valorization of Surveillance: Towards a Political Economy of Facebook," *Democratic Communiqué* 22, no. 1 (2008).
- Matthew Crain, "The Limits of Transparency: Data Brokers and Commodification," *New Media & Society*, 20, no. 1 (2018): 88–104.
- Aron Darmody and Detlev Zwick, "Manipulate to Empower: Hyper-Relevance and the Contradictions of Marketing in the Age of Surveillance Capitalism," *Big Data & Society*, 2020.

- Pam Dixon and Robert Gellman, "The Scoring of America: How Secret Consumer Scores Threaten Your Privacy and Your Future," *World Privacy Forum*, 2014.
- Steven Englehardt and Arvind Narayanan, "Online Tracking: A 1-Million-Site Measurement and Analysis," (2016).
- Greg Elmer, "Prospecting Facebook: The Limits of the Economy of Attention," *Media, Culture & Society* 41, no. 3 (2019): 332–346.
- Federal Trade Commission, "Data Brokers: A Call for Transparency and Accountability," May 2014.
- Forbrukerrådet, "Deceived by Design" (Oslo, 2018).
- Georg Franck, "The Economy of Attention," *Telepolis* (1999).
- Carolin Gerlitz and Anne Helmond, "The Like Economy: Social Buttons and the Data-Intensive Web," *New Media & Society* 15, no. 8 (2013): 1348–65.
- Kevin Ziyu Liu, "Commercial-State Empire: A Political Economy Perspective on Social Surveillance in Contemporary China," *The Political Economy of Communication* 7, no. 1 (2019).
- Rob Lucas, "The Surveillance Business," *New Left Review* 121 (2020): 132–41.
- Marie-Helen Maras and Adam Scott Wandt, "Enabling Mass Surveillance: Data Aggregation in the Age of Big Data and the Internet of Things," *Journal of Cyber Policy* 4, no. 2 (2019): 160–77.
- Duncan McCann and Miranda Hall, "Blocking the Data Stalkers: Going Beyond GDPR to Tackle Power in the Digital Economy" (London: New Economics Foundation, 2018).
- Lisa Petrison, Robert Blattberg, and Paul Wang, "Database Marketing: Past, Present, and Future," *Journal of Direct Marketing* 7, no. 3. (1993): 27–43.
- Leanne Roderick, "Discipline and Power in the Digital Age: The Case of the US Consumer Data Broker Industry," *Critical Sociology* 40, no. 5 (2014): 729–746.
- Richard Seymour, *The Twittering Machine* (London: Indigo Press, 2019).
- Dallas Smythe, "Communications: Blindspot of Western Marxism," *Canadian Journal of Political and Social Theory* 1, no. 3 (1977): 1–27.
- James Webster, *The Marketplace of Attention: How Audiences Take Shape in a Digital Age* (Cambridge: MIT Press, 2014).
- Tim Wu, *The Attention Merchants: How Our Time and Attention are Gathered and Sold* (London: Atlantic Books, 2017).
- Shoshana Zuboff, *In The Age Of The Smart Machine: The Future Of Work And Power* (New York: Basic Books, 1989).
- Shoshana Zuboff, "Big Other: Surveillance Capitalism and the Prospects of an Information Civilization," *Journal of Information Technology* 30, no. 1 (2015): 75–89.
- Shoshana Zuboff, "Google as a Fortune Teller: The Secrets of Surveillance Capitalism," *Frankfurter Allgemeine Zeitung*, March 5, 2016.
- Nils Zurawski, "Local Practice and Global Data: Loyalty Cards, Social Practices, and Consumer Surveillance," *The Sociological Quarterly* 52, no. 4 (2011): 509–527.

Week 8	Digital Colonialism
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Imperialism is a long-standing feature of the international system, yet it is taking on new aspects with the rise of digital platforms. This week will look at how the increasingly planetary platforms are reorganising the international order in their own image, how relations of hierarchy and dominance are being created, and how value is being channelled towards a handful of expansive digital empires. We will also examine how the globe is being carved up into different digital realms – arguably an American, Chinese, and European system of rules – and what this means for the future of the digital economy.

Required Readings

- Michael Kwet, "Digital Colonialism: US Empire and the New Imperialism in the Global South," *Race & Class* 60, no. 4 (2019): 3–26.
- Steven Weber, "Data, Development, and Growth," *Business and Politics* 19, no. 3 (2017): 397–423.

Further Resources

- Susan Ariel Aaronson and Patrick Leblond, "Another Digital Divide: The Rise of Data Realms and Its Implications for the WTO," *Journal of International Economic Law* 21 (2018): 245–72.
- Emanuel Adler, *The Power of Ideology: The Quest for Technological Autonomy in Argentina and Brazil* (Berkeley: California University Press, 2018).
- Susan Ariel Aaronson, "Information Please: A Comprehensive Approach to Digital Trade Provisions in NAFTA 2.0," CIGI Papers Series (Waterloo: Centre for International Governance Innovation, 2017).
- Shamel Azmeh and Christopher Foster, "The TPP and the Digital Trade Agenda: Digital Industrial Policy and Silicon Valley's Influence on New Trade Agreements," Working Paper Series (London: London School of Economics and Political Science, 2016).
- Jennifer Bair, "Global Capitalism and Commodity Chains: Looking Back, Going Forward," *Competition & Change* 9, no. 2 (2005): 153–80.
- Andrea Ballatore, Mark Graham, and Shilad Sen, "Digital Hegemonies: The Localness of Search Engine Results," *Annals of the American Association of Geographers* 107, no. 5 (2017): 1194–1215.
- Abeba Birhane, "Algorithmic Colonization of Africa," *Scripted* 17, no. 2 (2020): 389–409.
- Caribou Digital, "Paying Attention to the Poor: Digital Advertising in Emerging Markets" (Farnham, Surrey: Caribou Digital Publishing, 2017).

- Ulla Carlsson, "The Rise and Fall of NWICO: From a Vision of International Regulation to a Reality of Multilevel Governance," *Nordicom Review* 24, no. 2 (2003): 31–67.
- Dan Ciuriak, "The Digital Transformation and the Transformation of International Trade" (Geneva: International Centre for Trade and Sustainable Development (ICTSD) and the Inter-American Development Bank (IDB), 2018).
- Donald A. Clelland, "The Core of the Apple: Degrees of Monopoly and Dark Value in Global Commodity Chains," *Journal of World-Systems Research* 20, no. 1 (2014): 82–111.
- Zak Cope, *The Wealth of (Some) Nations: Imperialism and the Mechanisms of Value Transfer* (London: Pluto Press, 2019).
- Nick Couldry and Ulises A. Mejias, "Data Colonialism: Rethinking Big Data's Relation to the Contemporary Subject," *Television & New Media*, 15, no. 8 (2019): 336–349.
- Nick Couldry and Ulises Mejias, *The Costs of Connection: How Data Is Colonizing Human Life and Appropriating It for Capitalism* (Stanford: Stanford University Press, 2019).
- Carl Dahlman, Sam Mealy, and Martin Wermelinger, "Harnessing the Digital Economy for Developing Countries," OECD Development Centre Working Papers (OECD, 2016).
- Jason Dedrick, Kenneth L. Kraemer, and Greg Linden, "Who Profits from Innovation in Global Value Chains?: A Study of the iPod and Notebook PCs," *Industrial and Corporate Change* 19, no. 1 (2010): 81–116.
- Henry Farrell and Abraham Newman, "The Transatlantic Data War," *Foreign Affairs*, February 2016.
- Christopher Foster and Shamel Azmeh, "Latecomer Economies and National Digital Policy: An Industrial Policy Perspective," *The Journal of Development Studies* (2019): 1–16.
- Christian Fuchs, "New Imperialism: Information and Media Imperialism?," *Global Media and Communication* 6, no. 1 (2010): 33–60.
- Google, "Enabling Trade in the Era of Information Technologies: Breaking Down Barriers to the Free Flow of Information" (Mountain View: Google, 2010).
- Samuel Greengard, "Cloud Computing and Developing Nations," *Communications of the ACM* 53, no. 5 (2010): 18.
- David Harvey, *The New Imperialism* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2005).
- International Chamber of Commerce, "Trade in the Digital Economy - A Primer on Global Data Flows for Policymakers" (Paris: International Chamber of Commerce, 2016).
- Michael Keane and Haiqing Yu, "A Digital Empire in the Making: China's Outbound Digital Platforms," *International Journal of Communication* 13 (2019): 4624–4621.
- Vladimir Lenin, *Imperialism: The Highest Stage of Capitalism* (London: Penguin, 2010).

- Jinyan Li, "Protecting the Tax Base in the Digital Economy," Papers on Selected Topics in Protecting the Tax Base of Developing Countries (New York City: United Nations Department of Economic and Social Affairs, 2014).
- Michelle Markham, *The Transfer Pricing of Intangibles* (Kluwer Law International B.V., 2005).
- Shakir Mohamed, Marie-Therese Png, and William Isaac, "Decolonial AI: Decolonial Theory as Sociotechnical Foresight in Artificial Intelligence," *Philosophy & Technology*, 2020.
- Pun Ngai and Jenny Chan, "Global Capital, the State, and Chinese Workers: The Foxconn Experience," *Modern China* 38, no. 4 (2012): 383–410.
- Toussaint Nothias, "Access Granted: Facebook's Free Basics in Africa," *Media, Culture & Society* 42, no. 3 (2020): 329–48.
- Toks Dele Oyedemi, "Digital Coloniality and 'Next Billion Users': The Political Economy of Google Station in Nigeria," *Information, Communication & Society*, 2020.
- Renata Avila Pinto, "Digital Sovereignty or Digital Colonialism?," *Sur: International Journal on Human Rights* 15, no. 27 (2018): 15–27.
- Paola Ricaurte, "Data Epistemologies, The Coloniality of Power, and Resistance," *Television & New Media* 20, no. 4 (2019): 350–65.
- Cecilia Rikap, "Asymmetric Power of the Core: Technological Cooperation and Technological Competition in the Transnational Innovation Networks of Big Pharma," *Review of International Political Economy* 26, no. 5 (2019): 987–1021.
- Dan Schiller, "Transborder Data Flows," *Information Observatory* (blog), December 6, 2015.
- Parminder Jeet Singh, "Digital Industrialisation in Developing Countries: A Review of the Business and Policy Landscape" (The Commonwealth, 2018).
- The Macbride Commission, *Many Voices, One World: Towards a New, More Just, and More Efficient World Information and Communication Order* (Lanham, MD: Rowman & Littlefield Publishers, 2003).
- Tricontinental: Institute for Social Research, "The Rate of Exploitation (The Case of the iPhone)" (Buenos Aires, 2019).
- UNCTAD, "Information Economy Report 2013: The Cloud Economy and Developing Countries" (Geneva: UNCTAD, 2013).
- UNCTAD, "Digital Economy Report 2019: Value Creation and Capture - Implications for Developing Countries" (Geneva, 2019).
- US Trade Representative, "The Digital 2 Dozen" (Washington, D.C., 2016).
- Dovile Venskutonyte and Pieter Schinkel, "Bespoke Competition Policy for Developing Countries," 2015.
- Françoise Vergès, "Digital Africa," *Journal of the African Literature Association* 11, no. 1 (2017): 45–49.
- Daqing Yang, *Technology of Empire: Telecommunications and Japanese Imperialism, 1930–1945* (Cambridge: Harvard University Press, 2011).

Week 9	Capitalism or Something Worse?
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A number of theorists have argued that what we see emerging on the back of digital technologies is something different from capitalism. Some argue that we are reaching a new era of plenty, while others see a return of feudalist social relations. This week we will interrogate some of these perspectives in an effort to both adjudicate their claims and to shed light on what exactly digital capitalism might be.

Required Readings

- Jodi Dean, "Communism or Neo-Feudalism?," *New Political Science* 42, no. 1 (2020): 1–17.
- McKenzie Wark, *Capital Is Dead* (London: Verso, 2019), chapter 2.

Further Resources

- Neda Atanasoski and Kalindi Vora, *Surrogate Humanity: Race, Robots, and the Politics of Technological Futures* (Durham: Duke University Press, 2019).
- Jaius Banaji, *Theory as History: Essays on Modes of Production and Exploitation* (Chicago: Haymarket Books, 2011).
- Kean Birch, "Technoscience Rent: Toward a Theory of Rentiership for Technoscientific Capitalism," *Science, Technology, & Human Values*, 2019.
- Nick Bostrom, *Superintelligence: Paths, Dangers, Strategies* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2016).
- Erik Brynjolfsson, Daniel Rock, and Chad Syverson, "Artificial Intelligence and the Modern Productivity Paradox: A Clash of Expectations and Statistics," Working Paper (National Bureau of Economic Research, 2017).
- Colin Crouch, Marina Lalovic, and Evgeny Morozov, "Collective Responses to Digital Neofeudalism," *Eurozine*, October 17, 2017.
- Jodi Dean, "Neofeudalism: The End of Capitalism?," *Los Angeles Review of Books*, May 12, 2020.
- Nick Dyer-Witford, Atle Mikkola Kjoson, and James Steinhoff, *Inhuman Power: Artificial Intelligence and the Future of Capitalism* (Pluto Press, 2019).
- Marion Fourcade and Daniel N. Klutts, "A Maussian Bargain: Accumulation by Gift in the Digital Economy," *Big Data & Society* 7, no. 1 (2020).
- Joshua Gans, "Self-Regulating Artificial General Intelligence," Working Paper, Working Paper Series (National Bureau of Economic Research, 2018).
- Robert Gordon, *The Rise and Fall of American Growth: The U.S. Standard of Living since the Civil War* (Princeton: Princeton University Press, 2016).
- Michael Kaplan, "The Digital Potlatch: The Uses of Uselessness in the Digital Economy," *New Media & Society* 21, no. 9 (2019): 1947–66.

- Tahu Kukutai and John Taylor, eds., *Indigenous Data Sovereignty: Toward an Agenda* (Acton: Australian National University Press, 2016).
- Nick Land, "Machinic Desire," in *Fanged Noumena: Collected Writings 1987-2007*, ed. Robin Mackay and Ray Brassier (Falmouth: Urbanomic, 2011), 319–44.
- Jocelyn Maclure, "The New AI Spring: A Deflationary View," *AI & Society*, 2019.
- Scott Malcomson, *Splinternet: How Geopolitics and Commerce are Fragmenting the World Wide Web* (London: OR Books, 2016).
- Karl Marx, *Grundrisse: Introduction to the Critique of Political Economy*, trans. Martin Nicolaus (Middlesex: Penguin Books, 1973).
- Paul Mason, *Postcapitalism: A Guide to Our Future* (London: Allen Lane, 2015).
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Week 10	Alternative Futures
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Having taken a critical look at the global digital economy, in the final week we will try and interrogate what possible better futures might be possible. Ranging from minor reforms to wholesale revolutions, this week will aim to refute any sense of inevitability or necessity to our future and to assert the openness of what is possible. We will be particularly focused on platform cooperatives, blockchain promises, and transformative decolonial international orders.

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